

Is the east sale-ready?

● **NETWORK:** **AMBER** Looking ahead: Tue 6 – Sun 11 Oct

HOW'S EACH REGION HOLDING UP?

North

● GREEN

The usual sale-week strain, and nothing beyond it this week.

Watch: NH-44, and Delhi's truck rules

West

● GREEN

The usual sale-week strain. JNPA's latest report (Monday) has yards 56% full and trucks in and out in under two hours^[10]. The port looks fine.

Trend: steady

South

● GREEN

The usual sale-week strain for Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai. IMD expects a Bay low around 13th October (Tuesday) and gives it a low chance of becoming a depression^[3], which would be news, even in October.

Watch: the Bay low, and the Kerala ghats

East

● RED

Red for Thursday's Odisha bandh, which comes with blockades in the mining belts called specifically to stop mineral transport^[7], and Saturday's truck ban in Kolkata, both in the sale's first three days. Congress has also promised a seven-day mining blockade after Dussehra. Dates? Not yet^[8]. But the bit that actually worries me is the trend. After each sale opening, West Bengal's helpline searches went up 2.2 times in 2022, 2.5 in 2023, 3.8 in 2024 and 6.0 in 2025^[11]. That isn't the weather, it's structural.

Trend: worse from Thursday

Northeast

● AMBER

Amber for NH-10 into Sikkim, shut at night from Wednesday^[4], and for the Guwahati–Shillong–Silchar road after the weekend's rain. The rest of the region is running as the season usually does.

Watch: NH-10 and Siliguri

Central

● GREEN

The usual festive-week strain, and no weather warnings^[1]. Boring, in the best way possible.

Trend: steady

THE MAP, AND THE ROADS I'M WATCHING



NH-10 Siliguri–Gangtok

● AMBER

SIKKIM'S ONE AND ONLY TRUNK ROAD

Shut to all vehicles 9 pm to 6 am on the Sevoke–Rangpo stretch, 7th–15th October and again 26th October–5th November^[4].

NH-6 Guwahati–Shillong–Silchar

● AMBER

BARAK VALLEY, MIZORAM, TRIPURA

Heavy rain in Meghalaya over the weekend^[2], and slopes take a while to settle, so I'm holding it Amber till 7th October (Wednesday).

NH-44 Jammu–Srinagar

● AMBER

KASHMIR'S ALL-WEATHER LINK

Single-lane stretches in Udhampur and between Marog and Kishtwari Pather, Kashmir-bound tankers only 5 pm to 5 am beyond Chenani, and night travel? Advised against^[5].

NH-16 through Odisha

● RED

EAST COAST TRUNK, KOLKATA–CHENNAI

Red on Thursday for the Odisha bandh, then Amber while the trucks clear.

Kerala ghats into Idukki

● AMBER

KOCHI–MUNNAR–KUMILY ROADS

Isolated heavy rain today and again 9th–10th October, and rain across the state till 11th October (Sunday)^[1].

ACROSS THE COUNTRY, AND WHERE A DELAY COSTS MORE

1. Backlog and the first 72 hours

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Flipkart says it has added more than 900 festive delivery hubs^[15] and more than 2.5 lakh seasonal job openings^[16]. Traffic in ten big cities is only 1 to 6 points above usual today^[9], but every year it's the same story. In the four weeks after each of the last four sale openings, courier-helpline searches went up 1.2 to 1.9 times in Delhi, Maharashtra and Karnataka, and up to 2.8 times in Telangana^[12].

Backlog is like credit-card debt: whatever you carry into Thursday collects interest every day of the peak. Except, nobody gives you a loan in sale week. No spare riders, no spare trucks, everyone buying the same capacity. So outside the east, the first 72 hours decide the sale.

2. The Gulf is still shut

CENTRAL INDIA → MUNDRA → GULF · HIGH COST OF DELAY · HIGH CONFIDENCE

The sea leg is shut. UKMTO reported five incidents on Monday, four of them tanker strikes since Saturday^[18]. About 3 ships a day crossed Hormuz in the week to 27th September. In September 2025? 88 a day^[19]. India–Middle East rates are up 25–40% since late August^[20].

Unlike everything else on this page, this one won't clear when the festivals do. The exposure sits in every Gulf contract priced before late August.

3. Everyone's going west

EUROPE AND THE US, BY SEA VIA JNPA AND BY AIR VIA THE METROS · HIGH COST OF DELAY · HIGH CONFIDENCE

International air freight through Indian airports was up 15.5% on last year in August^[22], and India–US air tonnage is running 15% above last year^[23]. Everyone's going west, it seems.

So the space gets dearer just as the Christmas orders need it. The exposure sits with exporters whose peak orders still have nothing booked.

4. Who blinks first on diesel?

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

Nayara did, raising diesel by ₹3 a litre at its 7,108 outlets from 3rd October (Saturday)^[25], its second rise this year^[26]. The state retailers, who run over 90% of India's pumps, are holding Delhi at ₹95.20^[24], though ICRA estimated they lost about ₹9 a litre on diesel in September^[25]. And the Centre? Its diesel excise has been nil since March, so there's no duty left to cut^[27]. Remember May? More than 68 transport unions in Delhi-NCR struck for three days, with fuel costs among their demands^[28].

So will the state retailers raise prices during the festive weeks? Can they afford not to? I don't know, and I won't pretend to. What I do know is that the exposure sits in every contract with automatic diesel pass-through.

5. Rail is the only one adding seats

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

The Western freight corridor has run from Dadri to JNPA since 8th September (Tuesday), with double-stack trains to the port^[29]. Rail loading was up 5.4% in August, domestic containers 9.2%^[30], yet only about 14% of JNPA's boxes went by rail in FY26^[31]. Meanwhile, at GRAP Stage III Delhi restricts BS-IV and older diesel goods vehicles from outside, and the essential-goods exemption ends this month^[32].

Freight moved onto the corridor now is capacity booked before late October. After that, Delhi's rules take the older trucks out of the pool, just when every shipper wants road space.

DECISIONS THIS WEEK

- Sale volume lands on every metro hub at once on Thursday^[13,14]. **How much extra sort and linehaul do you run before early access opens on 8th October (Thursday)?** Whatever backlog you are sitting with on Thursday stays for the whole peak. There is no respite after it to clear the hubs.
- The east stops twice in the first three days of the sale - Odisha's bandh, then Kolkata's Mahalaya truck ban - and from 13th October, trucks serving Kolkata port get four hours a day, and none during the immersions^[6]. **Which eastern loads move before the bandh on 8th October (Thursday), and which Diwali-critical imports have to clear Kolkata port before the curbs start on 13th October (Tuesday)?** The curbs and bans run until 27th October (Tuesday), so going early is the least risky bet here.
- The Gulf route is shut, and westbound air and ocean space is getting tighter going into peak^[21]. **How much Europe and US space do exporters commit for peak-season orders while some is still available?** US air rates went up 7% in one week^[23]. Waiting for prices to drop sounds nice. May be they will, but I wouldn't bet the Diwali orders on it.

DATES TO WATCH		
Red dates stop freight, or flood it.		
Thu 8	Sale and early access open · Odisha bandh. Same day, of course.	
Sat 10	Kolkata's Mahalaya truck ban	
Sun 11	Navratri begins ^[17]	
13–27	Kolkata Puja curbs, then immersion bans	
Tue 20	Dussehra ^[17]	
26 Oct–5 Nov	NH-10 night closures, round two	
Sat 31	Delhi's essential-goods exemption for BS-IV goods vehicles ends ^[32]	

CALLS I'LL CHECK NEXT WEEK

- West Bengal's courier-helpline searches go up more than 2.2 times in the four weeks after the sale opens, as they have after every opening since 2022^[11].
- The state retailers hold Delhi diesel at ₹95.20 till at least 13th October (Tuesday)^[24].
- JNPA's yards stay under 70% full through the sale's first week^[10].

HOW I RATE THIS, AND WHAT I CAN'T SEE

I rate against the season, because a sale week is never going to look like a quiet week in July, right? A Red road drags down the hubs at both ends, and a hub stays Amber about two days after its cause clears, longer after a Red. Air shows up only with measured numbers (AAI, WorldACD). Confidence is High when the facts are dated and primary or measured, Medium when they rest on a proxy or a forecast.

Normal sale weeks come from Google searches for the Delhivery, Ekart, Blue Dart and DTDC helplines, each city read from its state: the busiest week in the four after Amazon's sale opens, against a normal week in the eight before. Mind you, they count customers chasing parcels, not late parcels, so they set the baseline, not the colour. The calls get scored next edition, so no hiding.

SOURCES

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